standing in Persia would rise to such an extent that it would be even harder to have him removed as leader of the Division. Should he fail, however, the Bolsheviks would increase their campaign and it would fall to Britain to prevent Persia disintegrating into anarchy. And should the British government's suspicions turn out to be true and Staroselskii actually defected to the Bolsheviks, it would be almost impossible to prevent the greater part of Persia from coming under Russian control.

Indeed, the success of Staroselskii in July in putting down a rebellion in the province of Mazandaran was contrasted unfavourably with the decision of the British government a few days later to evacuate their troops from Menjil in the face of tribal unrest.[68] By the end of August, the Division leader and his men had recaptured Recht and pressed on towards Enzeli, where they found themselves under heavy fire and were forced to retreat. Throughout September and October the Cossack Division would make several attempts to take Enzeli, but with no British support it was difficult to face the Bolshevik fleet.[69] While in 1920 the Cossack Division, the Red Army and the Persian rebels were busy fighting, the British forces seemed merely to be retreating – an unfortunate metaphor for Britain's position in Persia in general and a policy which made them more unpopular among the Persian people. Some saw the retreat as a sign of Britain's weakness; others thought that it was a calculated move because Britain did not care much about Persia; and some believed that the British were deliberately trying to frighten them by allowing Bolsheviks into the country so that the Persians would then clamour to Britain for help.[70]

As a reward for his efforts against the Bolsheviks, however, Staroselskii soon found himself deposed as the Cossack Division leader. Taking advantage of a temporary absence of the colonel in October, General Ironside – who was now commanding Norperforce – took control of the Division.[71] Simultaneously, Norman pressed upon the shah to dismiss the colonel; charging Staroselskii with incompetence and corruption, Norman threatened to withhold the royalties of the Anglo-Persian Oil Company from the government should the shah refuse. The shah had little choice but to acquiesce.[72] Although there was some criticism in London of the coup that Ironside and Norman had enacted, something had finally been done to